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CUET UG

Political Science

Challenge to and Restoration of Congress System

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
Succession after Nehru	Political succession after Nehru — the transition to Lal Bahadur Shastri and the 1966 contest between Indira Gandhi and Morarji Desai.	Tracing the democratic succession mechanisms, the 1965 crisis, and the role of the Congress Syndicate.
1967 Elections & Non-Congressism	Non-Congressism and electoral upset of 1967 — economic crisis, SVD coalition ministries, and political defections.	Analysing Rammanohar Lohia's thesis, the 8-state assembly losses, SVD instability, and "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram".
The Congress Split (1969)	Congress split and reconstitution — Indira versus the Syndicate, 10-Point Programme, 14 banks nationalisation, Privy Purses, and the 1969 Presidential election.	Distinguishing Congress (O) from Congress (R), the "conscience vote", and V.V. Giri's independent victory.
1971 Elections & Restoration	Congress' victory in 1971 elections, politics of 'garibi hatao', and the nature of the restored Congress system.	Contrasting the Grand Alliance's "Indira Hatao" with "Garibi Hatao", the 352-seat landslide, and the structural reinvention of the party.

EXAM PATTERN

CUET UG pattern (NTA official information bulletin and syllabus, 2026 cycle — the current 2027 baseline): each subject paper carries **50 compulsory questions** in **60 minutes**, with +5 for every correct answer and −1 for every incorrect answer. This chapter tests exact chronologies, slogans, party acronyms (Congress O vs R, SVD), presidential candidates, and the structural difference between Nehru's and Indira's party models.

The Succession Trials: 1964 and 1966

When Jawaharlal Nehru passed away on 27 May 1964, international observers openly questioned whether Indian democracy could outlive its founding prime minister. Western commentators predicted military takeover or political balkanisation; yet India pulled off two successive, peaceful leadership transitions in less than two years.

- **The First Succession — Lal Bahadur Shastri (May 1964):**
  - **The consensus choice:** K. Kamaraj, then Congress President, consulted party MPs and chief ministers. The party unanimously chose **Lal Bahadur Shastri** — a senior minister renowned for integrity, modesty, and administrative competence.
  - **A smooth democratic miracle:** The transition proved to the world that India's constitutional institutions did not depend on one individual.
  - **Shastri's dual crises:**
    - **Economic crisis:** Severe monsoon failures, widespread food grain scarcity, and dependence on American PL-480 wheat imports.
    - **The 1965 Indo-Pak War:** Pakistani military infiltration in Kashmir triggered full-scale armed conflict across the western border.
  - **The immortal rallying cry:** Shastri coined the slogan **"Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan"** (Hail the Soldier, Hail the Farmer), linking the soldier fighting at the frontier with the farmer producing food in the fields.
  - **The Tashkent tragedy (10 January 1966):** Shastri signed the UN/Soviet-brokered **Tashkent Agreement** with Pakistan's President Ayub Khan (mediated by Soviet Premier Alexei Kosygin). Hours after signing, Shastri died suddenly of a heart attack in Tashkent, throwing India into another succession test.
- **The Second Succession — Indira Gandhi versus Morarji Desai (January 1966):**
  - **An open contest:** Unlike 1964, consensus failed. **Morarji Desai** (former Chief Minister of Bombay and senior minister) insisted on a democratic vote against **Indira Gandhi** (daughter of Nehru and then Minister of Information and Broadcasting).
  - **The secret ballot:** Congress MPs voted by secret ballot. Indira Gandhi defeated Morarji Desai decisively, winning **355 votes to 169** (over two-thirds support).
  - **Why the Syndicate backed Indira:** The powerful regional bosses (the "Syndicate") calculated that Indira was politically inexperienced and would remain dependent on their guidance.
  - **Lohia's mocking label:** Socialist leader Rammanohar Lohia famously ridiculed Indira Gandhi as **"Gungi Gudiya"** (the Silent Doll) due to her hesitation in parliamentary debates — a label she would shatter within three years.

THE REGENTS AND THE YOUNG QUEEN

A powerful council of court elders (the Syndicate) installs a young, untested princess (Indira Gandhi) on the throne, believing she will serve as their decorative figurehead while they run the kingdom from behind the curtain. Instead, the young ruler builds a direct, devoted relationship with the common people outside the palace gates, fires the court elders one by one, and converts the royal council into a personal command staff. The mapping: the elders

= the Syndicate bosses; the princess = Indira Gandhi; the direct popular pact = the "Garibi Hatao" coalition.

The Fourth General Elections (1967): The "Political Earthquake"

The February 1967 General Elections were the first national elections held without Jawaharlal Nehru. The country was simmering with discontent, and the election results shattered the unshakeable hegemony Congress had enjoyed since 1952.

- **The Crisis Atmosphere of 1967:**
  - **Economic breakdown:** Two successive drought years, acute agricultural collapse, industrial recession, and double-digit inflation.
  - **The Rupee devaluation:** In June 1966, under heavy pressure from the US and the World Bank, Indira Gandhi devalued the Indian Rupee from ₹5 to over ₹7 per US dollar. The decision stoked widespread public outrage and price escalation.
  - **Popular protests:** Widespread bandhs, strikes, student unrest, and violent food riots broke out across the country. The government responded with police firing, worsening alienation.
- **Rammanohar Lohia and "Non-Congressism":**
  - **The core thesis:** Socialist thinker **Dr. Rammanohar Lohia** argued that Congress rule was undemocratic, elitist, and opposed to the interests of the impoverished masses.
  - **The electoral mathematics:** Congress stayed in power not because it had majority popular support, but because the non-Congress majority vote was split among dozens of rival opposition parties.
  - **The strategy:** Lohia advocated **Non-Congressism** — urging all non-Congress parties (regardless of ideology, from the Hindu-nationalist Jan Sangh to the Left) to form united electoral fronts to defeat the Congress monolith and protect Indian democracy.
- **The Verdict — The "Political Earthquake":**
  - **Lok Sabha decline:** Congress retained power at the Centre with its lowest seat tally (283 out of 520) and lowest popular vote share (40.8%) since 1952. Half of Indira Gandhi's cabinet ministers were defeated.
  - **Defeat of the Syndicate giants:** Syndicate kingpins lost their own seats — K. Kamaraj in Madras, S.K. Patil in Bombay, Atulya Ghosh in West Bengal.
  - **Loss of State Assemblies:** Congress lost power in **eight states** (seven failed to win majorities; an eighth, Haryana, was lost to post-poll defections).
  - **The Non-Congress geographical belt:** An unbroken stretch of non-Congress governments spanned northern and eastern India: Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal, Orissa, Madras (Tamil Nadu), and Kerala.
  - **The DMK historic triumph:** In Madras State, the **Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)** swept to power on an anti-Hindi platform, becoming the first regional party in independent India to secure a clear single-party majority in a state legislative assembly.

Coalitions and Defections: The SVD Phenomenon

The 1967 elections inaugurated two defining features of contemporary Indian politics: multi-party coalition governments and opportunistic legislative defections.

- **Samyukta Vidhayak Dal (SVD) Governments:**
  - **Strange bedfellows:** In states where no single party had a majority, joint legislative parties called **Samyukta Vidhayak Dal** were cobbled together.
  - **Ideological contradictions:** In Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the SVD ministries brought the right-wing **Bharatiya Jana Sangh**, the centrist **Swatantra Party**, the socialist **SSP/PSP**, and the communist **CPI** into the same cabinet.
  - **Inherent fragility:** Held together solely by anti-Congress opportunism rather than shared programs, SVD governments suffered continuous internal bickering, frequent cabinet collapses, and recurring spells of President's Rule.
- **The Defection Epidemic — "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram":**
  - **Definition:** A defection occurs when an elected legislator leaves the political party under whose symbol they won election and shifts allegiance to another party or coalition.
  - **The origin of the phrase:** In Haryana (1967), an independent MLA named **Gaya Lal** changed his party allegiance three times in a single fortnight — moving from Congress to United Front, back to Congress, and then back to United Front within nine hours!
  - **The press conference:** Haryana United Front leader Rao Birender Singh brought Gaya Lal to Chandigarh journalists and declared: **"Gaya Ram is now Aaya Ram."**
  - **The institutional fallout:** Defections became the primary instrument to topple ministries and install puppet chief ministers in Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh. The scourge persisted until the 52nd Constitutional Amendment enacted the Anti-Defection Law in 1985.

Political Phenomenon	Key Figures / Events	Core Exam Fact to Remember
Non-Congressism	Dr. Rammanohar Lohia (1967)	Strategic unity of all opposition parties to avoid splitting the anti-Congress vote.
Political Earthquake	1967 General Elections	Congress lost power in 8 states; reduced to 283 Lok Sabha seats; DMK won Madras alone.
SVD Coalitions	UP, Bihar, Punjab, MP (1967)	Samyukta Vidhayak Dal; ideological rivals (Jan Sangh + CPI) co-existed in unstable cabinets.
"Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram"	Gaya Lal (Haryana MLA, 1967)	Symbolised unprincipled floor-crossing and legislative defections for ministerial office.

The Split in the Congress (1969)

The defeat of the Syndicate in 1967 gave Indira Gandhi the opening to assert her authority. The simmering factional battle culminated in the open rupture of the ruling party in 1969.

- **The Underlying Divide — The Syndicate vs. Indira:**
  - **Who was the Syndicate?** A powerful informal clique of conservative party bosses: **K. Kamaraj** (Tamil Nadu, ex-Congress President), **S. Nijalingappa** (Mysore, Congress President), **S.K. Patil** (Bombay), **Atulya Ghosh** (West Bengal), and **N. Sanjeeva Reddy** (Andhra Pradesh).
  - **The core friction:** The Syndicate demanded that the Prime Minister consult the party organisation on all major policy and appointment decisions. Indira insisted on the absolute executive supremacy of the Prime Minister.
- **Indira's Radical Leftward Pivot:**
  - **The Ten-Point Programme (May 1967):** Social control of banking institutions, nationalisation of general insurance, ceiling on urban property, state trading in foodgrains, public distribution systems, and land reforms.
  - **The July 1969 Economic Package:**
    - **Bank Nationalisation:** Indira bypassed Parliament and issued an emergency ordinance nationalising **14 major private commercial banks**.
    - **Abolition of Privy Purses:** Announced the termination of hereditary cash pensions and privileges guaranteed to 565 former princely rulers under Article 291 and 362 of the Constitution.
    - **Morarji's exit:** When Finance Minister Morarji Desai expressed reservations, Indira unilaterally stripped him of the Finance portfolio. Desai resigned in protest.
- **The Catalyst — The 1969 Presidential Election:**
  - **The vacancy:** President Dr. Zakir Husain passed away in May 1969.
  - **The Syndicate's nominee:** The Congress Parliamentary Board, dominated by the Syndicate, nominated **N. Sanjeeva Reddy** (Speaker of the Lok Sabha) as the official Congress candidate, ignoring Indira's objections.
  - **Indira's counter-move:** Indira secretly encouraged Vice-President **V.V. Giri** to resign and contest as an Independent candidate.
  - **The whip vs. the conscience vote:**
    - Congress President S. Nijalingappa issued an official party whip directing all Congress MPs and MLAs to vote for Sanjeeva Reddy.
    - Nijalingappa held talks with opposition parties (Jan Sangh, Swatantra), giving Indira the moral high ground to accuse the Syndicate of colluding with right-wing reactionaries.
    - On the eve of voting, Indira Gandhi openly called upon electors to cast a **"free conscience vote"** (vote according to inner judgment, defying party whips).
  - **The election result:** V.V. Giri won the presidency in a dramatic contest, defeating the official Congress candidate Sanjeeva Reddy.
- **The Formal Rupture (November 1969):**
  - On 12 November 1969, Congress President Nijalingappa formally expelled Prime Minister Indira Gandhi from the Indian National Congress for indiscipline.

- The party fractured into two rival organisations:
  - **Congress (O) — Organisation:** Led by the Syndicate and Morarji Desai (the "Old Congress").
  - **Congress (R) — Requisitionists:** Led by Indira Gandhi and Jagjivan Ram (the "New Congress").
- **Survival as a minority government:** Indira lost her majority in the Lok Sabha, dropping to 220 seats. However, her government survived comfortably with issue-based external support from the **Communist Party of India (CPI)** and the **DMK**.

Comparison Feature	Congress (O) — "Old Congress"	Congress (R) — "New Congress"
Full Name	Congress (Organisation)	Congress (Requisitionists)
Key Leadership	K. Kamaraj, Nijalingappa, Morarji Desai, S.K. Patil	Indira Gandhi, Jagjivan Ram, Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed
Ideological Stance	Centrist-conservative, constitutionalist, status quo	Radical socialist, populist, pro-poor ("Garibi Hatao")
1969 Presidential Pick	N. Sanjeeva Reddy (Official Nominee)	V.V. Giri (Independent, backed via "conscience vote")
1971 Lok Sabha Fate	Reduced to a humiliating 16 seats	Swept an absolute majority of 352 seats

The 1971 General Elections & "Garibi Hatao"

In December 1970, Indira Gandhi took a bold constitutional gamble: she dissolved the Lok Sabha more than a year ahead of schedule, separating national parliamentary elections from state assembly elections for the first time in Indian history.

- **The Opposition Strategy — The "Grand Alliance":**
  - **The coalition:** Non-Congress and non-communist opposition parties formed an umbrella alliance: Congress (O), Bharatiya Jana Sangh, Swatantra Party, Samyukta Socialist Party (SSP), and Praja Socialist Party (PSP).
  - **The ideological vacuum:** The alliance possessed no shared economic blueprint. Their entire campaign was distilled into a single, personal negative attack: **"Indira Hatao"** (Remove Indira).
- **Indira's Masterstroke — "Garibi Hatao":**
  - **Turning attack into advantage:** Indira turned the opposition's negativity on its head. She famously proclaimed: **"They say Indira Hatao; I say Garibi Hatao"** (They want to remove Indira; I want to remove poverty).
  - **The radical agenda:** The 1971 manifesto promised progressive taxation, ceiling on rural and urban land ownership, bank credit for small farmers, employment generation, and the final abolition of Privy Purses.

- **The new social coalition:** Indira forged a cross-regional alliance of the historically marginalised: landless agricultural labourers, Dalits, Adivasis, religious minorities, youth, and women.

- **The Landslide Verdict of 1971:**
  - **Congress (R) sweep:** The Congress (R) - CPI alliance secured **375 seats** with 48.4% popular vote. Congress (R) alone won **352 seats** and 44% of votes — higher than Nehru's best tallies!
  - **Annihilation of Congress (O):** The Grand Alliance was decimated to less than 40 seats. The Syndicate's Congress (O) was reduced to just 16 seats.
  - **Consolidation via the 1971 War:** In December 1971, India defeated Pakistan in a 13-day war, liberating Bangladesh. Opposition leaders (including Atal Bihari Vajpayee) hailed Indira as "Durga". In the 1972 State Assembly elections, Congress (R) swept back to power across virtually every state.

Restoration or Reinvention? The Changed Congress System

Did Indira Gandhi simply "restore" the old Congress system that had dominated India under Jawaharlal Nehru? Political scientists conclude that while Congress restored its **electoral dominance**, the internal nature and character of the party had been **completely reinvented**.

- **The Structural Shift — Nehru's Model vs. Indira's Model:**
  - **Nehru's Congress (The Pluralist Umbrella):**
    - Operated as an inclusive coalition accommodating multiple classes, ideologies, and regional factions.
    - Internal factions acted as balancing mechanisms; state leaders (Chief Ministers and PCC presidents) enjoyed high autonomous political standing.
    - Decisions were hammered out through consensus and compromise.
  - **Indira's Restored Congress (The Command Structure):**
    - Transformed into a highly centralised, hierarchical command vehicle subordinate to the supreme authority of the Prime Minister.
    - Internal party elections were suspended; organizational bodies withered.
    - State Chief Ministers and party chiefs were not chosen by local legislators, but directly appointed as hand-picked loyalists from New Delhi.
- **The Fatal Institutional Weakness:**
  - The new Congress was electorally invincible so long as Indira's personal charisma held sway.
  - However, by destroying the intermediate regional leaders and internal dispute-resolution committees, the party lost its capacity to absorb local social tensions.
  - When the economic shocks of the 1973 OPEC oil crisis and drought hit, public frustration could not be channeled through party structures — exploding instead into direct popular movements (Gujarat agitation, Bihar Movement led by Jayaprakash Narayan), ultimately culminating in the declaration of the National Emergency in June 1975.

Dimension	Nehru's Congress System (1947–1964)	Indira's Restored Congress (Post-1971)
Party Architecture	Broad inclusive umbrella; multiple ideological shades.	Homogeneous populist-socialist vehicle.
Decision Making	Consensus-driven; internal factional bargaining.	High Command command-structure; top-down directives.
State Leadership	Powerful regional bosses with grassroots mass followings.	Centrally nominated loyalist Chief Ministers.
Democratic Resilience	High capacity to absorb social conflicts through accommodation.	Low capacity; popular dissent bypassed party and hit the streets.

High-Yield Chronology & Personalities

- **27 May 1964:** Jawaharlal Nehru passes away; Lal Bahadur Shastri takes oath as Prime Minister.
- **September 1965:** Indo-Pak War; Shastri coins **"Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan"**.
- **10 January 1966:** Tashkent Agreement signed; Shastri dies suddenly in Tashkent.
- **January 1966:** Indira Gandhi defeats Morarji Desai in secret ballot (355–169) to become PM.
- **June 1966:** Devaluation of Indian Rupee under World Bank pressure.
- **February 1967:** Fourth General Elections ("Political Earthquake"); Congress loses 8 states; SVD coalitions arise.
- **May 1967:** Indira Gandhi floats the Ten-Point Programme.
- **May 1969:** President Zakir Husain passes away.
- **July 1969:** Indira nationalises 14 major commercial banks; Morarji Desai resigns.
- **August 1969:** V.V. Giri elected President of India via "conscience vote", defeating official nominee N. Sanjeeva Reddy.
- **November 1969:** Congress formally splits into Congress (O) and Congress (R).
- **December 1970:** Fifth Lok Sabha dissolved ahead of term.
- **March 1971:** Fifth General Elections; Congress (R) sweeps 352 seats on the slogan **"Garibi Hatao"**.
- **December 1971:** Indo-Pak War leads to the liberation of Bangladesh; Congress dominance consecrated.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture

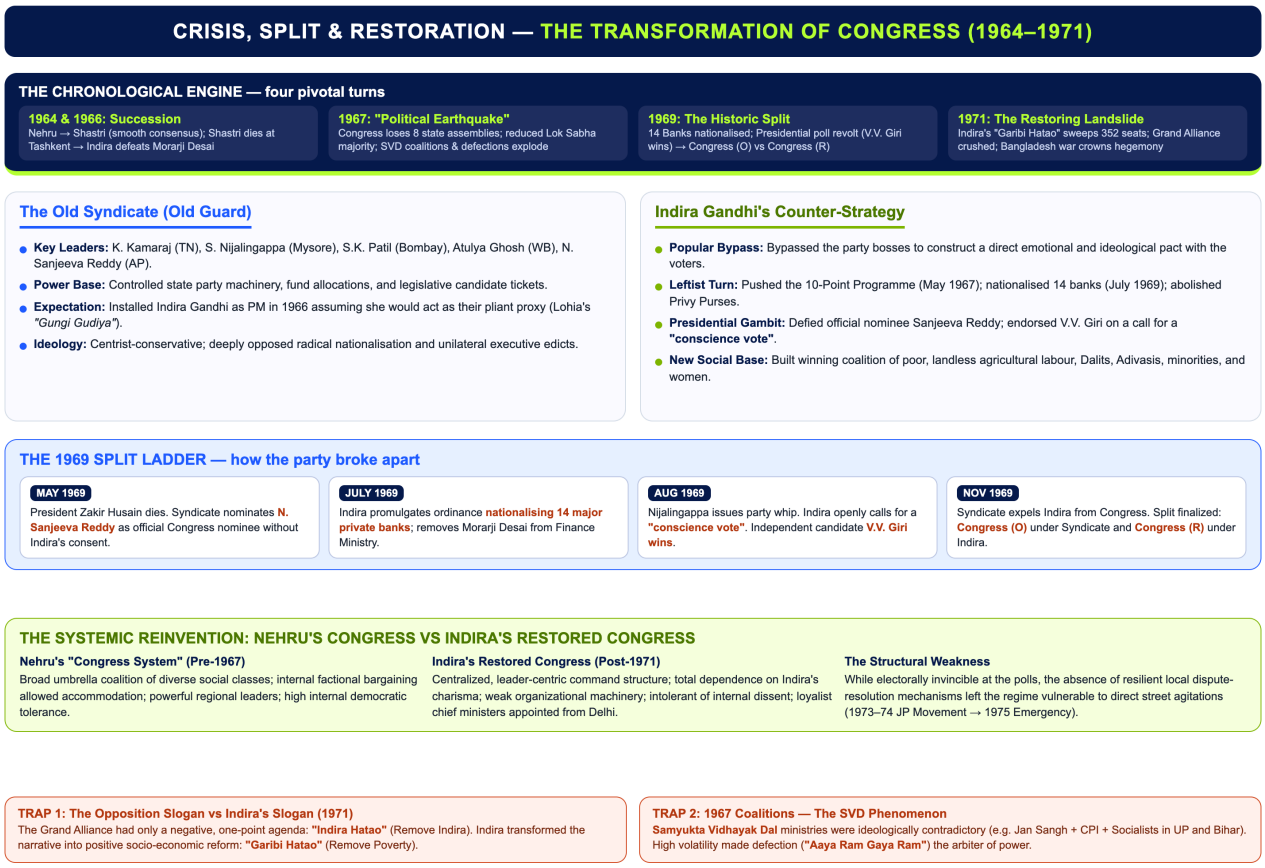


Figure 1: The Congress Crisis & Restoration Engine (1964–1971): Dual succession, the 1967 electoral upset, the 1969 factional split, and the transformation from Nehru's umbrella party to Indira's centralized socialist command structure.

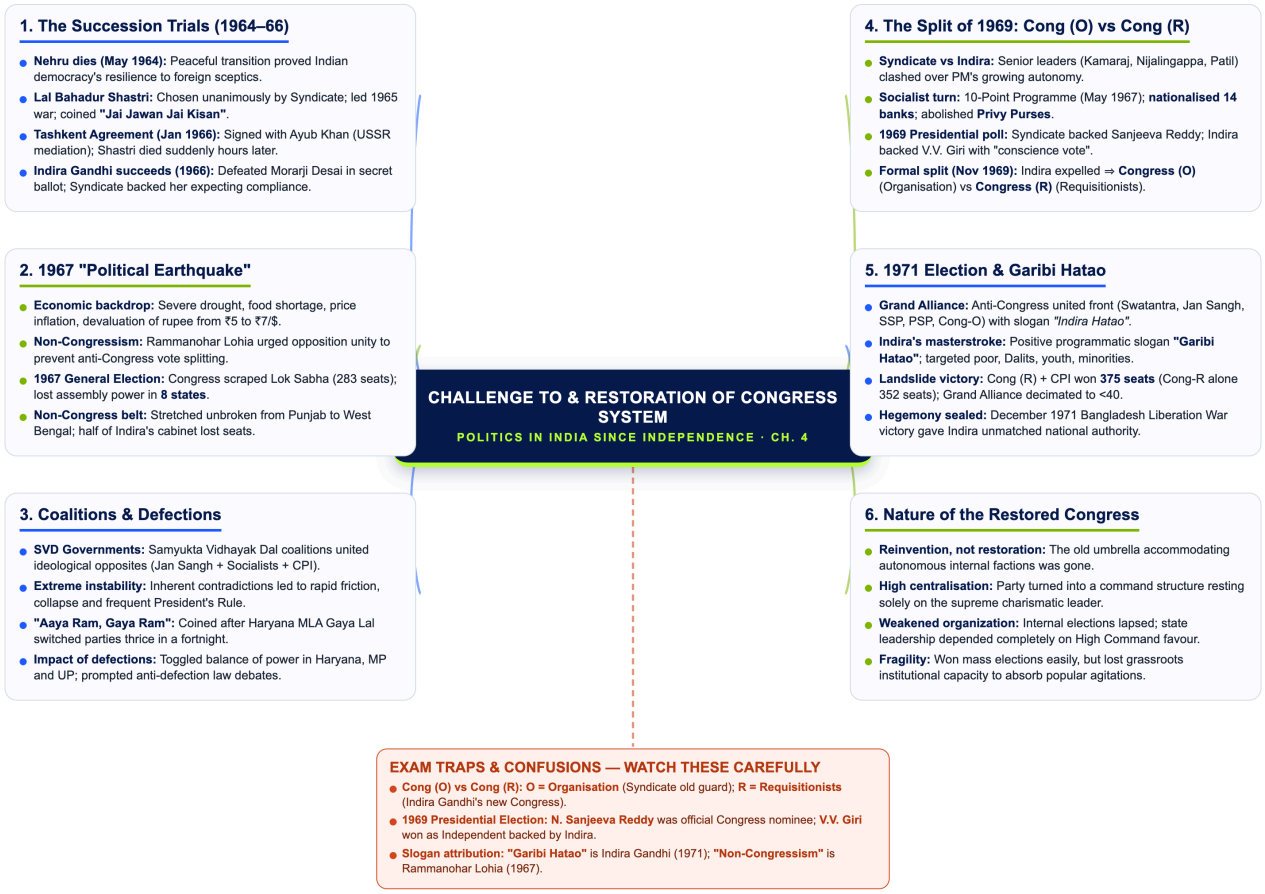


Figure 2: Complete Chapter Mindmap: Successions, 1967 Political Earthquake, Coalitions and Defections, The Great Split of 1969, The 1971 Landslide, and the nature of the Restored Congress system.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions in the authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. Who succeeded Jawaharlal Nehru as the Prime Minister of India in May 1964?

(A) Morarji Desai
(B) Gulzarilal Nanda
(C) Lal Bahadur Shastri
(D) K. Kamaraj

Q2. The famous slogan “Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan” was coined by Lal Bahadur Shastri during the:

(A) 1962 Sino-Indian War
(B) 1965 Indo-Pak War
(C) 1967 General Elections
(D) First Five Year Plan launch

Q3. The term “Non-Congressism” was propounded in 1967 by which political thinker and leader?

(A) Jayaprakash Narayan
(B) C. Rajagopalachari
(C) Dr. Rammanohar Lohia
(D) Acharya Kripalani

Q4. In the 1967 Fourth General Elections, Congress failed to secure an absolute majority in how many state legislative assemblies?

(A) Four states **(B)** Six states
(C) Seven states **(D)** Ten states

Q5. The infamous phrase "Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram" entered Indian political vocabulary following repeated defections by an MLA named Gaya Lal in which state?

(A) Punjab **(B)** Uttar Pradesh
(C) Haryana **(D)** Bihar

Q6. How many major commercial banks were nationalised by an executive ordinance promulgated by Indira Gandhi in July 1969?

(A) 10 banks **(B)** 14 banks
(C) 20 banks **(D)** 8 banks

Q7. In the historic 1969 Presidential Election, who won the presidency as an Independent candidate backed by Indira Gandhi's call for a "conscience vote"?

(A) N. Sanjeeva Reddy **(B)** V.V. Giri
(C) Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed **(D)** Dr. Zakir Husain

Q8. Following the split of the Indian National Congress in November 1969, the faction led by the Syndicate was known as:

(A) Congress (R) **(B)** Congress (O)
(C) Congress (I) **(D)** Congress (S)

Q9. What was the central election slogan deployed by Indira Gandhi to counter the Grand Alliance's "Indira Hatao" in the 1971 General Elections?

(A) Jai Jawan Jai Kisan **(B)** Garibi Hatao
(C) Sampoorn Kranti **(D)** Congress Lao, Desh Bachao

Q10. In the 1971 Fifth Lok Sabha elections, how many seats did Indira Gandhi's Congress (R) win on its own?

(A) 283 seats **(B)** 352 seats
(C) 375 seats **(D)** 414 seats

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. Lal Bahadur Shastri succeeded Nehru as Prime Minister in June 1964 following a unanimous consensus process led by Congress President K. Kamaraj. Gulzarilal Nanda served only as interim PM for a few days.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q2. Shastri coined "Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan" during the 1965 war with Pakistan to salute the dual pillars of national defense and food self-sufficiency during the agrarian crisis.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. Dr. Rammanohar Lohia, the veteran socialist theoretician, propounded "Non-Congressism" to unite the fragmented opposition vote and overthrow the Congress monopoly.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. Congress failed to get a majority in 7 states directly in the elections, and lost an 8th (Haryana) to immediate defections, creating a non-Congress belt in 8 state assemblies.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Gaya Lal was an MLA from Hassanpur in Haryana who switched parties three times within a fortnight in 1967, giving birth to Rao Birender Singh's famous quip "Gaya Ram is now Aaya Ram".

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. Indira Gandhi nationalised 14 major private commercial banks in July 1969 through an emergency ordinance, triggering the resignation of Deputy PM and Finance Minister Morarji Desai.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. V.V. Giri won the 1969 election as an Independent candidate against the official Congress nominee N. Sanjeeva Reddy after Indira called for a "conscience vote".

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The Syndicate faction was designated Congress (Organisation) or Congress (O), while Indira Gandhi's breakaway party was designated Congress (Requisitionists) or Congress (R).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. Indira Gandhi countered the opposition's negative "Indira Hatao" with her famous populist pledge "Garibi Hatao" (Abolish Poverty), clinching a nationwide pro-poor vote base.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. Congress (R) won 352 seats on its own (and 375 together with ally CPI), completely decimating the Grand Alliance and proving that Indira's party was the real Congress.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option B	Picking the interim caretaker	Gulzarilal Nanda was interim PM; Shastri was the chosen substantive Prime Minister.
Q4 option D	Counting 8 including defections	Elections: 7 states lost majority at the polls; Haryana was the 8th lost via post-poll defection.
Q7 option A	Selecting the official party candidate	Sanjeeva Reddy was the official Syndicate nominee who LOST to V.V. Giri.
Q8 option A	Flipping Congress O and R	Congress (O) = Organisation (Syndicate); Congress (R) = Requisitionists (Indira).
Q10 option C	Adding the CPI alliance total	352 seats = Congress (R) alone; 375 seats = Congress (R) + CPI coalition combined.

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